“If I speak up, I'll be punished.”

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Where it often comes from

Speaking up has cost some people dearly: in families where disagreement brought anger, at schools or churches where questions were treated as rebellion, or at workplaces where complaints led to retaliation. We learn to stay quiet, swallow concerns, and agree on the surface.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, “God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power, love, and self-control.” The Lord told Joshua, “Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go.” Proverbs says, “The righteous are as bold as a lion.” Mordecai asked Esther, “Who knows if perhaps you have come to the kingdom for such a time as this?” and the apostles answered, “We cannot stop speaking about what we have seen and heard.” Courage does not mean recklessness. We can speak truthfully and respectfully, choosing wisely when and how, and trusting God with the result.

> *“For God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power, love, and self-control”* (2 Timothy 1:7).

Also see

> “Have I not commanded you to be strong and courageous? Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go” (Joshua 1:9).

> “The wicked flee when no one pursues, but the righteous are as bold as a lion” (Proverbs 28:1).

> “For if you remain silent at this time, relief and deliverance for the Jews will arise from another place, but you and your father’s house will perish. And who knows if perhaps you have come to the kingdom for such a time as this?” (Esther 4:14).

> “Instead, speaking the truth in love, we will in all things grow up into Christ Himself, who is the head” (Ephesians 4:15).

Common self-statements

- If I say anything, I will pay for it.
- It is safer to stay quiet.
- They will retaliate.
- No one wants to hear what I think.
- I will lose my job or the relationship.
- Speaking up never works.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Predicting punishment.
- Catastrophizing: Imagining the worst response.
- Overgeneralizing: Treating a past punishment as certain now.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I must either stay silent or confront.

Challenging questions

- When was I punished for speaking up in the past?
- Is this situation the same, or different?
- What is the actual risk, and what is the cost of staying silent?
- What is the wisest way and time to say it?
- What does God say about fear and courage?
- Who could support me or help me prepare?

Truth summary

> God has given me a spirit of power, love, and self-control. I can speak truthfully and respectfully, choosing the right time and way. If the risk is real, I can prepare, seek counsel, and protect myself.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Fear
- Communication
- Witness
- Protection
- Will of God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Communication
- Anxiety/Worry/Fear

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

Same Power — Jeremy Camp
God's power challenges the belief that evil or fear has the final authority.

Battle Belongs — Phil Wickham
Bring fear and uncertainty to God rather than carrying the outcome alone.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If I speak up, I'll be punished"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If I speak up, I'll be punished." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ When was I punished for speaking?
- ☐ Is this the same?
- ☐ What is the real risk?
- ☐ What do I want to say?
- ☐ When and how?
- ☐ Who can support me?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God has not given me a spirit of fear.
- ☐ The Lord is with me wherever I go.
- ☐ I can speak with respect.
- ☐ I can choose my time and way.
- ☐ Silence has a cost too.
- ☐ I can get support.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 2 Timothy 1:7
  "For God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power, love, and self-control."
- ☐ Joshua 1:9
  "Have I not commanded you to be strong and courageous? Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go."
- ☐ Ephesians 4:15
  "Instead, speaking the truth in love, we will in all things grow up into Christ Himself, who is the head."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] A truth spoken: Each week, record one honest, respectful thing you said.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 2 Timothy 1:7 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God has given me power, love, and self-control, so I can speak the truth with respect.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Fear" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Write what you want to say. Draft it in one or two sentences.
- [ ] Rehearse. Practice with a friend or counselor.
- [ ] Choose the setting. Pick a calm time and place.
- [ ] Document and seek counsel. If the risk is real, keep records and consult HR or an adviser.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I speak up, I'll be punished": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A truth spoken
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I speak up, I'll be punished.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, speaking up has felt dangerous. You have not given me a spirit of fear. Give me wisdom, courage, and gentleness, and protect me as I speak the truth in love. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.